philanthropy and above all, the freedom movement. If Marwari capital had ‘placed the feet of the English’ inside India in the 18th century, it would also ensure their departure as it played an important role in financing the activities of Gandhi and the Indian National Congress.[55]

Marwaris made the transition from trade to industry, famously into Calcutta’s jute mills, relatively late, in the early 20th century. Post-Independence, the significance of Calcutta in the Marwari world declined. Militant trade unions led to capital flight and the Marwaris began leaving Calcutta in large numbers for other Indian cities, especially Delhi and Bombay. Marwaris also left earlier settlements in the Gangetic belt and the Assam valley towards places with better opportunities. Significant female migration had begun with speedy and safe passage assured by trains after the completion of a railway corridor linking Shekhawati and Calcutta in 1916. Over the 20th century, Marwari male-dominated semi-permanent migration gave way to more permanent migration of families.[56] By the end of the 20th century, the Marwari diaspora exceeded 2 million, a third of which was located in seven major cities. Mumbai now hosts the maximum number of Marwaris with other metropolitan cities such as Pune, Chennai, Hyderabad and Bengaluru catching up with Kolkata. The largest concentration, however, continues to live in the districts and smaller towns of Maharashtra such as Nashik, Jalgaon, Dhule, Ahmednagar, Solapur, Aurangabad, Chandrapur and more. Collectively, this region hosts nearly a million Marwaris who continue to be associated with trading and moneylending but have also moved into other sectors such as cultivation, irrigation, construction and real estate. The rise of Nandlal Dhoot, founder of the billion-dollar Videocon Group, is an example of successful Marwari entrepreneurship from this relatively unheard of Marwari diaspora. He studied in Ahmednagar and Pune, made profits from sugarcane and cotton cultivation and set up a sugar mill in 1955 before becoming one of the first industrialists from the Marathwada region.

Marwari migrations have been closely linked with state patronage, a flair for spotting opportunities in new regions and also moving out early from regions with declining opportunities. In the early 20th century, the largest